STARWEAVER®

Non-Graded Project: Producing and Operationalizing a Defensible Intelligence Assessment

Learning Objectives

By the end of this project, learners will be able to:

Frame an intelligence requirement aligned to a real decision and distinguish signal from operational noise. (Module 1)

Evaluate collected data and intelligence outputs using defensible performance criteria. (Module 2)



Apply structured analysis to translate intelligence findings into operational and strategic implications. (Module 3)

Recommend program-level improvements that integrate intelligence into defensive workflows and align to leadership decision needs. (Module 4)



Description

Producing and Operationalizing a Defensible Intelligence Assessment

Threat intelligence delivers value only when it changes operational outcomes. Yet many intelligence programs struggle to demonstrate decision impact—producing more reports, ingesting more indicators, and running more hunts without clarity on whether any of it is making the organization safer. In this project, you'll step into the role of a senior analyst tasked with answering the hardest question a threat intelligence team faces: is our

intelligence program delivering decision advantage, or just amplifying activity?

Using a realistic enterprise scenario, you'll apply the full analytical toolkit from ATI—distinguishing signal from noise, evaluating program effectiveness with structured criteria, translating findings into operational implications, and recommending measurable improvements aligned to leadership needs. Your final deliverable will be a concise, defensible intelligence brief that demonstrates analytical clarity, assumption transparency, and decision alignment.

This project offers a hands-on opportunity to integrate intelligence tradecraft, structured analysis, and program-level thinking into a single assessment, mirroring the kind of work expected of intelligence professionals operating at the intersection of analysis and operations.

Structure of the Project

Title: Producing and Operationalizing a Defensible Intelligence Assessment

Tools: Mural (free tier) and any word processor

Scenario

You are a senior analyst embedded within a mature enterprise threat intelligence program supporting a globally distributed organization operating in finance, manufacturing, and digital services.

Over the past six months, your organization has significantly expanded its intelligence capabilities. Investments include multiple commercial threat feeds, external threat landscape dashboards, internal threat hunting teams, weekly executive intelligence briefings, and automated indicator ingestion pipelines.

Activity levels have increased. Reporting volume has grown. Threat maps show heightened global activity. Internal hunts are occurring more frequently. Yet despite these improvements, executive leadership has expressed concern:

“We receive more intelligence than ever, but what decisions has it changed?”

“Confidence language shifts between briefings.”

“Some insights arrive after response decisions are already underway.”

Recently:

- External dashboards show elevated scanning and exploit attempts against identity infrastructure globally.
- Three internal hunts were launched based on external indicators; two produced benign findings tied to normal administrative activity.
- One hunt identified suspicious credential use, resulting in containment actions.

> A nation-state–linked intrusion attempt was detected later than desired but ultimately contained.

Leadership has tasked you with conducting a structured evaluation of the intelligence program. You are not being asked to collect new data or attribute adversaries. Instead, you must assess whether the intelligence program is delivering decision advantage—or amplifying activity without impact.

Objective

Your goal is to produce a concise, defensible intelligence assessment that frames the problem clearly, evaluates program effectiveness, communicates analytic confidence and limitations, and recommends operational actions and program improvements. This exercise will help you integrate intelligence tradecraft across all four ATI modules into a single, decision-aligned deliverable.



Follow these steps to complete this project

Step 1: Signal vs. Noise Assessment

- Using only the scenario information:
  - Identify one example of intelligence output that represents signal and one that represents noise.
  - For each example, write a brief explanation covering:
    - Why it qualifies as signal or noise.
    - What decision it supported (or failed to support
    - One key assumption influencing your assessmen

Your analysis should demonstrate disciplined reasoning and explicit assumption management.

Step 2: Intelligence Effectiveness Evaluation

Select two evaluation criteria from the following: timeliness, decision relevance, confidence clarity, alignment to intelligence requirements, operational impact, or executive clarity.

- For each selected criterion:
  - Assess current performance (Strong / Mixed / Weak).
  - Provide evidence from the scenario.
  - Identify one organizational risk if the issue is not addressed.

Your evaluation should demonstrate structured performance analysis—not volume measurement.

Step 3: Operational and Strategic Integration

Using the structured analytic framework (How do I know? If true, what happens next? What assumptions must be true?), identify:

- One key intelligence gap affecting performance.
- One follow-on intelligence requirement that would reduce uncertainty.
- One operational or architectural adjustment that could result from improved intelligence alignment.

Demonstrate how intelligence transitions from reporting to operational impact.

Step 4: Program-Level Improvement Recommendation

Recommend one concrete program-level improvement. This must not be a tool purchase. Examples include: revising executive briefing structure, standardizing confidence language, implementing intelligence performance KPIs, formalizing intelligence-to-hunt governance, or establishing structured feedback loops.

- Define the specific problem it addresses.
- Explain how success would be measured.
- Identify which leadership decision it is intended to improve.

Explain how it reduces noise or increases signal.

Step 5: Write Executive Intelligence Brief

Synthesize your findings from Steps 1–4 into a concise executive-facing intelligence brief (approximately 300–400 words) structured as follows:

Current Intelligence Posture: Is the organization intelligence-advantaged, intelligence-neutral, or intelligence-noisy? Justify using structured reasoning.

Decision Impact: Identify one leadership decision positively influenced by intelligence and one area where intelligence failed to create clarity.

Primary Strategic Risk: State the single most important intelligence-related risk, reflecting signal/noise discipline, measurement gaps, integration weaknesses, and leadership communication.

Strategic Way Ahead: Recommend one integrated next step that improves signal clarity, strengthens operational alignment, enhances executive confidence, and includes a measurable success indicator.

Organize information following this structure for peer review:

1. Title Page: Project title, your name, date
2. Signal vs. Noise Assessment: One signal example, one noise example, with reasoning and assumptions
3. Effectiveness Evaluation: Two criteria assessed with evidence and organizational risk
4. Operational Integration: Intelligence gap, follow-on requirement, and operational adjustment
5. Program Improvement: Concrete recommendation with measurable outcome and leadership alignment

6 Executive Intelligence Brief: One-page synthesis covering posture, decision impact, strategic risk, and way ahead

Instructions for Documenting and Sharing the Project for Peer Review

1. Document the Project

- Create your assessment as a structured written document using word processing software.
- Organize under the five step headings (Signal/Noise, Effectiveness, Integration, Improvement, Executive Brief).

- Keep sections concise and focused—total submission of approximately 800–1,000 words.
- Save as a PDF.

2. Share the Project



- Upload to the “Peer Review” area.
- Include a brief description of your primary findings and recommendations.

3. Peer Review

- Review other students' assessments.
- Provide constructive feedback on analytic reasoning, assumption of transparency, decision alignment, and recommendation clarity.

By completing this project, you'll gain practical experience in producing defensible intelligence assessments that integrate signal discipline, structured evaluation, operational translation, and program-level thinking—the core skill set expected of intelligence professionals operating at the intersection of analysis and decision support.